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NEWSPAPER 30th OCTOBER, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

44th WEEK



BHUTAN-INDIA RELATIONS ... CHALLENGES

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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

30th OCTOBER, 2018

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New PM, new challenges

Dr Lotay Tshering, whose party has won the elections, wants to reduce dependence on hydroelectricity, a sector in which India is heavily invested. With China lurking, an old relationship enters a crucial phase

CHURN IN THE NEIGHBOURHOOD

SHUBHAJIT ROY
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 28

CHURN IN THE NEIGHBOURHOOD (DNT), or Bhutan United Party, has emerged the winner in the final round of parliamentary elections in Bhutan, votes for which were cast on October 18. These parliamentary elections were the third since Bhutan transitioned to a constitutional monarchy 10 years ago.

Bhutan has a two-round election system, much like France. In the first round held in September, all four registered political parties contested, and the incumbent People's Democratic Party (PDP), led by Tshering Tobgay, finished third. The final round this month saw a contest between the Drak Phensung Tobgay (DPT), or Bhutan Peace and Prosperity Party, and the DNT.

The DNT first contested in 2013 and finished third in the first round. This time, it has won 30 seats in the National Assembly, the 47-seat elected lower House of Bhutan's Parliament. The DPT has won 17 seats.

Bhutan's three elections so far have produced three different winners. The DPT won in 2008, and PDP in 2013.

Centre-Left choice

DNT is headed by Dr Lotay Tshering, a 50-year-old surgeon who has an MBA from Thakur University and has specialised in general surgery. He also has an MBA from California University. The Prime Minister-elect has worked at Thimphu's national medical hospital, then as a hospital in the country, as an assistant surgeon and ophthalmologist.

DNT's slogan, "Narrowing the Gap" between the rich and the poor, has resonated among its large grassroots base. Bhutanese people, apart from their social-democratic principles, and which regulate fresh water, a new life and new beginning. In 127 pages, the government is addressing inequality in income and access to services and opportunities in health, education and other areas.

These ideas from the relatively new party have clearly resonated with voters after the DPT and PDP governments of Prime Ministers Jigme Thinley (2008-13) and Tshering Tobgay (2013-18). Inequality is a



Dr Lotay Tshering, a surgeon and ophthalmologist by training, is the leader of the Drak Phensung Tobgay (DPT), Bhutan's new ruling party.

major issue in Bhutan — some experts have estimated that incomes in the mining sector, for example, could be about 11,000 times the national average.

Poll, votes, voters

Seventy-one per cent — about 1,34,000 — of the over 4,30,000 registered voters in the nation of about 150,000 people voted in the final round. The turnout was higher than the 96.30% in the primary round and the 96.15% in 2013, indicating rising voter awareness and stronger efforts by the Election Commission. The DNT got 53% of the vote.

Postal voters numbered about 1,14,000 — an increase from 30% of the total — and had a decisive influence on the outcome. Some observers have pointed out that the bulk of the postal ballots were cast by government servants who live in Thimphu, away from their home constituencies, and it is interesting that they chose the new DNT.

Bhutanese media have referred to poll servants as the "forty-eight-hour constituency".

Among the voters, there were more women (about 1.59 lakh) than men (1.54 lakh). The number of women in the National Assembly is over, more than double the three women MPs that the DPT defeated last. The DNT has five women MPs, the DPT two.

Social media battles

A lot of the campaign took place on social media, mainly Facebook (which has about 4,00,000 users in Bhutan) and Viber Chat. There was some trolling, and the Election Commission responded with fines, penalties, and take-down requests. In the primary round, 15 Facebook posts by party supporters were

found to be in breach of social media and election laws. In the final round, there were 28 such posts, 16 of which could not be removed. Some media clips dragged Bhutan's second monarchy into the heat and dust of the campaign. This was seen as a violation of the Constitution — Article 2, Section 11 says that the person of the Druk Gyalpo, i.e., Monarch, "shall be sacrosanct", and Article 11 makes it "the duty and responsibility" of "every person", to respect and abide by the provisions of the Constitution. The country's official newspaper, *Kuensel*, wrote in an editorial: "The degradation of monarchy to dirty divisive politics is undemocratic and profane. As a society, we stand through a transition, no political parties and their workers should have the audacity to malign the monarchy, the nation's symbol of unity."

Economy, India, China

Bhutan's grossing (GDP) in 2017, but also has high youth unemployment and external debt. In 2017, India was 10.6% of GDP, as per World Bank figures from that year, 80% of the country's external public debt (up to 77% of GDP) stems from its hydroelectric projects, mostly financed by India. New Delhi is also the largest buyer of Bhutanese hydropower, a sector that makes up 14% of the GDP and 27% of the government's revenue. The DNT wants to diversify the economy and reduce its reliance on hydroelectricity.

Bhutan also depends on subsidised gas and kerosene from India, and the DPT government paid the price when India decided to withdraw the subsidies just before the elections of 2013, in response to then Prime Minister Jigme Thinley's perceived outreach

to China. The DNT has suggested the introduction of biogas and electric cars.

Dr Tshering's party also wants to encourage agriculture, make teaching a lucrative profession, and increase public-sector wages. Healthcare is a key focus, and so is the PM-Jeet.

While foreign policy did not figure in the campaign, India has been the elephant in the room whenever parties have talked about the economic situation and public debt. India provides budgetary support to Bhutan's development and backs it against Chinese expansionism. This was displayed during the two-and-a-half-month DNT-India standoff last year. In the Bhutanese scheme, the PM conducts himself with day-to-day functioning of the country, while the monarchy has the decision-making powers of national security and foreign policy. It is in New Delhi's interest to have the incoming PM aligned with his predecessor and the monarchy.

Earlier this year, Beijing sent a top official, equivalent to the Foreign Secretary, to open a channel for dialogue with Thimphu. Some Indian observers claim that this is a ploy to find a voice in its dealings with other countries. And while traditional and mainstream media in Thimphu have been restrained, there have been numerous influential social media over a perceived "Indian veto" on which countries can open embassies in Thimphu or how and when Bhutan should engage with the world. China doesn't yet have an embassy in Bhutan's capital.

For India, the challenge is to align with the rising expectations of an impatient people who are seemingly no longer satisfied by the philosophy of "Gross National Happiness" as concrete economic challenges of a credit crunch, high loan interest rates, unemployment and high inflation loom. Many in Bhutan feel that the country's traditional growth model, India should now be linked to enhanced Indian generosity in providing it with development support.

In his authoritative *The History of Bhutan* (2011), the scholar Karma Phuntsok has likened the country's relationship with India to "that of a successful daughter to a protective mother". The daughter has "grown up, found her independent voice and life, but the mother finds it difficult to let her go". And on the relationship with China, writes Phuntsok, "Bhutan remains cautious, like a shy daughter influenced by her mother to keep away from an unwelcome suitor".

The question is, for how long?

BY NEXT: MALDIVES

The Indian EXPRESS
JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

29th October, 2018

4 Bhutan | New PM, new challenges

Dr Lotay Tshering, whose party has won the elections, wants to reduce dependence on hydroelectricity, a sector in which India is heavily invested. With China lurking, an old relationship enters a crucial phase.

Druk Nyamrup Tshogpa (DNT), or Bhutan United Party, has emerged the winner in the final round of parliamentary elections in Bhutan, votes for which were cast on October 18. These parliamentary elections were the third since Bhutan transitioned to a constitutional monarchy 10 years ago.

Bhutan has a two-round election system, much like France. In the first round held in September, all four registered political parties contested, and the incumbent People's Democratic Party (PDP) led by Tshering Tobgay finished third. The final round this month saw a contest between the Druk Phuensum Tshogpa (DPT), or Bhutan Peace and Prosperity Party, and the DNT.

The DNT first contested in 2013 and finished third in the first round. This time, it has won 30 seats in the National Assembly, the 47-seat elected lower House of Bhutan's Parliament. The DPT has won 17 seats.

Bhutan's three elections so far have produced three different winners. The DPT won in 2008, and PDP in 2013.

Centre-Left choice

DNT is headed by Dr Lotay Tshering, a 50-year-old urologist who has an MBBS from Dhaka University, and has specialised in general surgery. He also has an MBA from Canberra University. The Prime Minister-elect has worked at Thimphu's national referral hospital, the main hospital in the country, as a consultant surgeon and urologist.

4 Bhutan | New PM, new challenges

DNT's slogan, "Narrowing the Gap" between the rich and the poor, has socialist overtones. Its logo is peach blossom (khamsing meto), a plant identified with social democratic principles, and which signifies fresh hope, a new life and new beginning. Its 103-page manifesto promises to address inequality in income and access to services and opportunities in health, education and other areas.

These ideas from the relatively new party have clearly resonated with voters after the DPT and PDP governments of Prime Ministers Jigme Thinley (2008-13) and Thsering Tobgay (2013-18). Inequality is a major issue in Bhutan — some experts have estimated that incomes in the mining sector, for example, could be almost 17,000 times the national average.

Poll, votes, voters

Seventy-one per cent — about 3,14,000 — of the over 4,38,000 registered voters in the nation of about 7,50,000 people voted in the final round. The turnout was higher than the 66.36% in the primary round and the 66.1% in 2013, indicating rising voter awareness and stronger efforts by the country's Election Commission. The DNT got 55% of the vote.

Postal votes numbered about 1.14 lakh — an enormous 36% of the total — and had a decisive influence on the outcome. Some observers have pointed out that the bulk of the postal ballots were cast by government servants who live in Thimphu (away from their home constituencies), and it is interesting that they chose the newbie DNT.

Bhutanese media have referred to civil servants as the "forty-eighth constituency".

Among the voters, there were more women (about 1.59 lakh) than men (1.54 lakh). The number of women in the National Assembly is seven, more than double the three women MPs that the 2013 elections sent. The DNT has five women MPs; the DPT two.

4 Bhutan | New PM, new challenges

Social media battles

A lot of the campaign took place on social media, mainly Facebook (which has about 4,00,000 users in Bhutan) and WeChat. There was some mudslinging, and the Election Commission responded with fines, penalties, and takedown requests. In the primary round, 15 Facebook posts by party supporters were found to be in breach of social media and election laws; in the final round, there were 28 such posts, 18 of which could not be removed.

Some audio clips dragged Bhutan's revered monarchy into the heat and dust of the campaign. This was seen as a violation of the Constitution — Article 2, Section 15 says that the person of the Druk Gyalpo, i.e., Monarch, "shall be sacrosanct", and Art 8, Sec 11 makes it "the duty and responsibility" of "every person... to respect and abide by the provisions of this Constitution". The country's official newspaper, Kuensel, wrote in an editorial: "To drag in the institution of monarchy in dirty divisive politicking is undemocratic and profane. As a tense society strides through a transition, no political parties and their workers should have the audacity to malign the monarchy, the nation's symbol of unity."

Economy, India, China

Bhutan is growing fast (8% in 2017), but also has high youth unemployment and external debt. In 2017, its debt was 108.6% of its GDP; as per World Bank figures from that year, 80% of the country's external public debt (equal to 77% of GDP) stems from loans for hydropower projects, mostly financed by India. New Delhi is also the largest buyer of Bhutanese hydropower, a sector that makes up 14% of the GDP and 27% of the government's revenue. The DNT wants to diversify the economy and reduce its reliance on hydroelectricity.

4 Bhutan | New PM, new challenges

Bhutan also depends on subsidised gas and kerosene from India, and the DPT government paid the price when India decided to withdraw the subsidies just before the elections of 2013, in response to then Prime Minister Jigme Thinley's perceived outreach to China. The DNT has suggested the introduction of biogas and electric cars.

Dr Tshering's party also wants to incentivise agriculture, make teaching a lucrative profession, and increase public-sector wages. Healthcare is a key focus area for the PM-elect.

While foreign policy did not figure in the campaign, India has been the elephant in the room whenever parties have talked about the economic situation and public debt.

India provides budgetary support to Bhutan's development and backs it against Chinese expansionism. This was displayed during the two-and-a-half-month Doklam standoff last year. In the Bhutanese scheme, the PM concerns himself with the day-to-day functioning of the country, while the monarchy has the decisive say in matters of national security and foreign policy. It is in New Delhi's interest to have the incoming PM aligned with his predecessor and the monarchy.

Earlier this year, Beijing sent a top official, equivalent to the Foreign Secretary, to open a channel for dialogue with Thimphu. Some Indian apprehensions notwithstanding, Bhutan's young democracy has been fast finding a voice in its dealings with other countries. And while traditional and mainstream media in Thimphu have been restrained, there have been murmurs in Bhutanese social media over a perceived "Indian veto" on which countries can open embassies in Thimphu, or how and to what extent Bhutan should engage with the world. China does not yet have an embassy in Bhutan's capital.

4 Bhutan | New PM, new challenges

For India, the challenge is to align with the rising expectations of an impatient people who are seemingly no longer satisfied by the philosophy of “Gross National Happiness” as concrete economic challenges of a credit crunch, high loan interest rates, unemployment and high inflation loom. Many in Bhutan feel that the country’s traditional goodwill towards India should now be linked to enhanced Indian generosity in providing it with development support. In his authoritative *The History of Bhutan* (2013), the scholar Karma Phuntsho has likened his country’s relationship with India to “that of successful daughter to a possessive mother”. The daughter has “come of age, found her independent voice and life... but the mother finds it difficult to let her go”. And on the relationship with China, writes Phuntsho, “Bhutan remains cautious, like a shy daughter influenced by her mother to keep away from an unworthy suitor”. The question is, for how long?

4

New PM, new challenges

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CHURN IN THE NEIGHBOURHOOD

part 2

BHUTAN

SHUBHAJIT ROY
NEW DELHI, OCTOBER 28

DR. LOTAY TSHERING (DNT), of Bhutan United Party, has emerged the winner in the final round of parliamentary elections in Bhutan, which were held on October 18. Three parliamentary elections were the third since Bhutan transitioned to a constitutional monarchy 10 years ago.

Bhutan has a two-round election system, much like France. In the first round held in September, all four registered political parties contested, and the incumbent People's Democratic Party (PDP), led by Tshering Tobgay, finished third. The final round, this month, saw a contest between the Drak Nyensung Tshogpa (DNT), or Bhutan Peace and Prosperity Party, and the DNT.

The DNT first contested in 2013 and finished third in the first round. This time, it was won 30 seats in the National Assembly, the 47-seat elected lower house of Bhutan's Parliament. The PDP won 17 seats.

Bhutan's three elections so far have produced three different winners. The DNT won in 2008, and PDP in 2013.

Centre-Left choice

DNT is headed by Dr Lotay Tshering, a 50-year-old surgeon who has an MBA from Tsinghua University and has specialised in general surgery. He also has an MBA from California University. The Prime Minister-elect has worked at Tsinghua's national medical hospital, then as a hospital director in the country, as a consultant surgeon and ophthalmologist.

DNT's slogan, "Narrowing the Gap" (between rich and poor), has resonated with voters. Its logo is a peach blossom (Shangmo), a symbol identified with social democratic principles, and which signifies fresh hope, a new life and new beginning. Its 101-page manifesto promises to address inequality in income and access to services, and opportunities in health, education and other areas.

These ideas from the relatively new party have clearly resonated with voters after the DNT and PDP governments of Prime Ministers Jigme Thinley (2008-13) and Tshering Tobgay (2013-16). Inequality is a



Dr Lotay Tshering, a surgeon and ophthalmologist by training, is the leader of the Drak Nyensung Tshogpa (DNT), Bhutan's new ruling party.

major issue in Bhutan — some experts have estimated that income in the mining sector, for example, could be almost 10,000 times the national average.

Poll, votes, voters

Seventy-one per cent — about 134,000 — of the over 4,38,000 registered voters in the nation of about 1,50,000 people voted in the final round. The turnout was higher than the 96,300 in the first round and the 96,15 in 2013, indicating strong voter awareness and stronger efforts by the country's Election Commission. The DNT got 53% of the vote.

Postal votes numbered about 1,14,000 — an enormous 30% of the total — and had a decisive influence on the outcome. Some observers have pointed out that the bulk of the postal ballots were cast by government servants who live in Thimphu away from their home constituencies, and it is interesting that they chose the smaller DNT.

Bhutanese media have referred to civil servants as the "forty-nights constituency". Among the voters, there were more women (about 1,50 lakh) than men (1,54 lakh). The number of women in the National Assembly is now more than double the three women MP's that the 2013 elections sent. The DNT has the women MP's, the DNT too.

Social media battles

A lot of the campaign took place on social media, mainly Facebook (which has about 4,00,000 users in Bhutan) and WeChat. There was some mudslinging, and the Election Commission responded with fines, penalties, and suspensions. In the primary round, 15 Facebook posts by party supporters were

found to be in breach of social media and election laws. In the final round, there were 28 such posts, 16 of which could not be traced.

Some earlier clips, dragged, Bhutan's second round into the final and last of the campaign. This was seen as a violation of the Constitution — Article 2, Section 11 says that the person of the Drak Gyals, i.e., Monarch, "shall be sacrosanct", and Article 11 makes it "the duty and responsibility" of "every person... to respect and abide by the provisions of the Constitution". The country's official newspaper, *Kuntok*, wrote in an editorial: "In doing so, the institution of monarchy is duly divine protecting its sacredness and justice. A nation's society is divided through a transition, no political parties and their workers should have the authority to judge the monarchy; the nation's symbol of unity."

Economy, India, China

Bhutan's grossing (GDP) in 2017, but also its high youth unemployment and external debt in 2017. India was 10.8% of its GDP, as per World Bank figures from that year. 30% of the country's external public debt (equivalent to 7% of GDP) stems from loans for hydropower projects, mostly financed by India. New Delhi is also the largest buyer of Bhutanese hydropower, a sector that makes up 14% of the GDP and 27% of the government's revenue. The DNT wants to diversify the economy and reduce its reliance on hydroelectricity.

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to China. The DNT has suggested the introduction of biogas and electric cars.

Dr Tshering's party also wants to increase agriculture, make teaching a better profession, and increase public sector wages. Healthcare is a key issue, and for the PM-elect.

While foreign policy did not figure in the campaign, India has been the elephant in the room whenever parties have talked about the economic situation and public debt. India provides budgetary support to Bhutan's development and backs its against Chinese expansionism. This was displayed during the two-and-a-half-month Doklam standoff last year. In the Bhutanese scheme, the PM consults himself with the day-to-day functioning of the country, while the monarchy has the decision say in matters of national security and foreign policy. It is in New Delhi's interest to have the incoming PM aligned with his predecessor and the monarchy.

Earlier this year, Beijing sent a top official, equivalent to the Foreign Secretary, to open a channel for dialogue with Thimphu. Some Indians apprehensions notwithstanding, Bhutan's growing democracy has been fast finding a voice in its dealings with other countries. And while traditional and mainstream media in Thimphu have been restrained, there have been numerous influential social media over a perceived "Indian veto" on which countries can open embassies in Thimphu, or how and to what extent Bhutan should engage with the world. China cannot yet have a embassy in Bhutan's capital.

For India, the challenge is to align with the rising expectations of an independent people who are seemingly no longer satisfied by the philosophy of "Cross National Happiness" as concrete economic challenges of a credit crunch, high loan interest rates, unemployment and high inflation looms. Many in Bhutan feel that the country's national goal of self-reliance India should now be linked to enhanced Indian generosity in providing it with development support.

In his authoritative *The History of Bhutan* (2013), the scholar Karma Phuntsok has likened the country's relationship with India to "that of a successful daughter to a parent-sister-in-law". The daughter has "come of age, found her independent voice and life... and the mother finds it difficult to let her go." And on the relationship with China, writes Phuntsok, "Bhutan remains cautious, like a shy daughter influenced by her mother to keep away from an unworthy suitor".

The question is, for how long?

BY NEXT: MALADIVES

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

India and its neighborhood- relations.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Examine the special relationship as per the 2007 Treaty between India & Bhutan and critically analyze the challenges to this relationship.



The Indian **EXPRESS**
JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

29th October, 2018



NEWS REPORT

**TSHERING TOBGAY**

PRIME MINISTER OF BHUTAN

**LOTAY TSHERING**

PRESIDENT OF DNT



*He is going to become
the next Prime Minister*

- 1 Druk Nyamrup Tshogpa Party has won the recent general elections in Bhutan.
- 2 It won 30 of the National Assembly's 47-seats, while Druk Phuensum Tshogpa got only 17 seats.
- 3 The National Assembly is the lower house of Bhutan Parliament
- 4 This is the third general election after democracy was adopted in Bhutan in 2008.



ROLE OF PM AND MONARCHY IN BHUTAN

In the Bhutanese scheme, PM concerns with day-to-day functioning, while monarchy has the decision in national security and foreign policy.

Bhutan has two-round election system just like France and in the first round, all four registered political parties contested, and the incumbent People's Democratic Party (PDP) led by Tshering Tobgay finished third. And, now the final round held between the two contestants.

BHUTAN AND ITS PRESENT STATUS



TSHERING TOBGAY

PRIME MINISTER OF BHUTAN

1 Bhutan is growing faster at about 8% in 2017.

2 It also has high youth unemployment and external debt.

3 In 2017, its debt was 108% of GDP.

4 80% of the Country's external public debt stems from loans for hydropower projects, mostly financed by India.

5 New Delhi is also the largest buyer of Bhutanese hydropower.

6 The sector makes up 14% of GDP in Bhutan and 27% of the Government's revenue.

The Government now wants to diversify the economy and reduce its reliance on hydroelectricity.

INDIA AND BHUTAN ... SPECIAL RELATION

**LOTAY TSHERING**

PRESIDENT OF DNT, PM ELECT

- 1 Neither Government shall allow the use of its territory for activities harmful to the national security and interest of the other.
- 2 Equal justice for their subjects in each others territories

- 3 Free trade and commerce between India and Bhutan.
- 4 Bhutan shall be free to import, from or through India into Bhutan, whatever arms, ammunition, machinery, warlike material or stores as may be required.
- 5 India gives loans for hydro-electric projects and purchases power from Bhutan.
- 6 India provides budgetary support to Bhutan's development and backs it against Chinese expansionism.

3 Many feel that Country's traditional goodwill towards India, should enhance Indian generosity in providing it with more development support.



1 The challenge is to align with the rising expectations of impatient youth, who are no longer satisfied with "Gross National Happiness".



LOTAY TSHERING
PRESIDENT OF DNT, PM ELECT

2 There are concerns of high loan interest rates, unemployment and high inflation.

CHALLENGES
FOR INDIA

Scholar Karma Phuntsho has likened his Country's relationship with India to that of a successful daughter to a possessive mother. The daughter has come of age, found her independent voice and life, but the mother finds it difficult to let her go!

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SINCERE THANKS
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